lion in aid to the Palestinians. Significantly, Saudi Arabia too expressed solidarity with the Palestinian cause, with the state media reporting that Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman was working to prevent "an expansion" of the conflict. Meanwhile, Iran, while denying charges that it helped Hamas execute the attack, extended fulsome support to the Palestinian cause and projected itself as the prime defender of the Muslim faith. Iran was backed by its allies in Iraq and Yemen, who even threatened to extend military support to the Palestinians in case Israel launched a major ground offensive.

MODI'S TOUGH STAND

On his official account on X (formerly Twitter), Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed India's unequivocal support to Israel. "We stand in solidarity with Israel in this difficult hour," he said. The prime minister reiterated that message when Netanyahu called him three days after the Hamas strike and took to X again to declare: "India strongly and unequivocally condemns terrorism in all its forms and manifestations." While several experts appreciated PM Modi's expression of solidarity with Israel and strong condemnation of acts of terror, others felt India's response could have been more nuanced. Like restating its long-standing support for a two-state solution, which advocates peaceful coexistence for Israel and Palestine.

Many, however, defended Modi's action, recalling that in 2018 he became the first Indian PM to visit the West Bank, the headquarters of the Palestinian Authority (PA), and have a bilateral meeting with President Mahmoud Abbas. The Modi government had also extended economic assistance to Palestinians for education, healthcare and technology. There was no reason, therefore, to doubt the government's support to the Palestinian cause. Meanwhile, a resolution issued by the Congress reiterated the party's support for the Palestinian cause, calling for a ceasefire and negotiations, but it was criticised by the BJP for not specifically condemning the brutal terror attacks by Hamas.

While it remains uncertain whether the conflict will spread to other West Asian states, fresh turmoil in the region, along with the ongoing Ukraine war, will be a cause for major worry for the rest of the world, including India. The immediate impact is expected to be on oil prices, which were already high at $84 a barrel before the Hamas strike and may rise further if the conflict becomes prolonged or spreads to other regions. The Hamas strike itself is being viewed as more than just another local conflict with Israel. It has wider geopolitical ramifications that add a fresh dimension to the emerging post-Covid world order in which the US and China represent two poles, and which India will have to navigate nimbly in coming months.

WHILE RIGHTLY CONDEMNING THE TERROR STRIKES ON ISRAEL, INDIA NEEDS TO BE MORE NUANCED IN ITS RESPONSE AS THE GAZA WAR COULD STRAIN ITS GROWING ECONOMIC TIES WITH THE ARAB WORLD

INDIA AND ISRAEL
FROM BLOW COLD TO BLOW HOT

PHASE 1: 1947-1992

BLOW COLD

India backs Palestinian claims for legitimacy. While India recognised Israel in 1950, it declined to have any diplomatic relations with the country. In 1974, India becomes the first non-Arab state to recognise the Palestine Liberation Organization as the legitimate representative of the Palestinian people; in 1988, India was one of the first nations to recognise the Palestinian state.

WHY HAMAS STRUCK

There are no clear answers yet on why Hamas chose to strike and with such immense force, but there have been several recent triggers. Among them are the rapid moves Israel has been making to build bridges with the Arab world that once shunned ties with it. These include the Abraham Accords signed with the UAE, Bahrain, Morocco and Sudan, brokered by the US, which pushed for normalisation of ties. With the Saudi government also inclined to move towards an agreement, the Palestinians were concerned that their struggle for a separate homeland was not a priority for Arab states any more. The interests of Hamas, though a Sunni-dominated group, therefore, converged with those of Shia-dominated Iran: it lay in stopping the growing rapprochement between the Arab world and Israel.

The other motive was Hamas's perception that the PA was becoming toothless and losing the stomach to fight for the Palestinian cause any more. Headed by the aging Abbas, the PA's influence is said to be waning in the West Bank, one of the two enclaves that are internationally recognised as being under its administration, Gaza being the other. Bordering Jordan, the West Bank is 10 times larger than Gaza in area, houses 3 million Palestinians and is controlled by the Fatah. Gaza is a tiny strip of coastal land 41 km long and 6-12 km wide that lies 50 km from the West Bank and borders Egypt on the south. It has a population of 2 million. When Gaza came under Hamas control in 2007, Israel imposed an air, sea and land blockade